

Chat Within Gmail!

Gmail is rolling out a chat feature that's browser-based and integrated into Gmail. If you don't know whether you already have this feature, log in to your Gmail account. If you're presented with a full-page help text on the chat feature, then you have it.



The Death Of The Password

Bill Gates has predicted the demise of the traditional password. Security firm RSA is working with Microsoft to develop a SecurID technology for Windows. SecurID is a two-factor authentication system. It generates a constantly-changing sequence of numbers that one has to type in alongside the regular password.



Enter

Jimmy Shergill
Actor

Ever since his debut in *Maachis*, Jimmy Shergill has been making intermittent appearances with films such as *Mohabbatein*, *Charas* and *Dil Vil Pyar Vyar*. He was last seen in *Yahaan*. Here, Jimmy is giving us his take on technology.

What does technology mean to you?

I find technology indispensable. I am a complete gadget freak, and have most of what is available.

What gadgets do you own?

I have so many gadgets, it's difficult to name them all. But the gadgets that I use most are my Apple laptop and the iPod nano. Then, there is also my mobile phone—the Nokia N70

What do your online activities entail?

I spend my time online when not at work or with my family. I love cars and use the Net to look up features on new models. Besides, the Internet is a tool through which I stay connected to my family when away on shoots.

Ever had a make or mar situation with technology?

Most gadgets are quite helpful. But I've had my share of the downs. Once, at a shoot in a remote location, I felt stranded due to unavailability of signals on my phone. Also, there are no data cards available for my Apple Mac and this is a huge impediment. I await the day when the cards will be available.

THE COMING WAR

Paid Pipes?

The telcos in charge of the **fat** Internet pipes in the US could soon be meddling with the content that travels along those pipes, going by recent developments. The idea is for content providers to pay ISPs money for data packets to and from their Web sites to get priority. What does this mean to the user? The telcos' proposals have the potential to alter the flow of information, and therefore your personal experience, on the Internet.

In theory, if Yahoo! paid for such a service, and Google didn't, your searches at Yahoo! would be faster. Now, it's only the bigger players who'd be able to afford (or would want to spend on) the prioritisation schemes, so a small Web site that's just starting up might end up being too slow, and therefore losing out on visibility. What would have happened if such a scheme had existed back when Google was a startup, and AltaVista had paid... Google might just have died out!

There are several issues involved. At the basic level, companies would say, why not? They're just promoting their business! And packet prioritisation is one means to that end. It seems perfectly OK if you think about it from the site operators' point of view. But not so OK if you think from the user's perspective: it's sort of infringes on your rights. It borders on the undemocratic. You feel you have a right to see what you

want to on the Internet; with the network favouring certain sites, someone is controlling what you see. Of course, access to "non-premium" sites wouldn't be blocked, but when you see a site is slow, you're probably going to trash it and go to the next search result. Similarly, if iTunes was a "premium customer," for example, you'd get faster downloads from their site, and you probably wouldn't switch to a fledgling music downloads site that actually had a better selection.

Content prioritisation can be taken even further. Consider that many US ISPs offer services—such as music downloads—that compete with those of other vendors. So would people be pulled into subscribing to their ISP's offerings?

Common sense seems to indicate that Internet pipes should be neutral. Controlling content over the pipes is like allowing, for a fee, some newspapers to get to the stands sooner. This is the first time we're coming across something that contradicts this, but it turns out network neutrality (or the lack of it) is not a new concept. However, it's only recently, with more broadband penetration and improvements in packet-analysis technology, that ISPs are finding it

worthwhile to consider using the technology and creating services out of it.

The telcos say these proposed prioritisation schemes would not alter the nature of the Internet: giving priority to a company that pays more, they say, is just like offering another tier of service.

It will be up to the US congress to decide whether packet prioritisation will be allowed; what decisions are made could spell out the fate of the Internet—whether it will remain democratic, or whether we'll create a Net where only wealthy sites get seen and heard.

ANOTHER PRIVACY CONCERN

Google Hosts Your Data!

Google recently released Google Desktop 3, which introduces the ability to



Illustrations Harsho Mohan Chatteraj